NOTICE!

Starting next fall, the University of Rochester serves Garbage Plates at admitted-students day and at commencement.

WHAT WE'D DO

Put Rochester's least photogenic meal on our most photographed days. Not a dining-hall option: an official ritual, bought from local plate shops. Families touring campus eat what Rochester actually eats.

WHAT PUSHES BACK

Rankings culture. Glossy "almost-Ivy" branding. Wellness marketing. Every peer school's interchangeable brochure.

THE COST YOU CAN SEE

An image hit. Some health-minded and prestige-minded applicants quietly cross us off. Admissions eats it first; tuition payers later.

IS THAT THE BIGGEST COST?

Probably not. Plates are cheap, and lost applicants were never committed. The bigger risk is quieter: lower yield, then lower rankings. I'm betting it doesn't happen.

WHY NOBODY CAN COPY IT

Any school can serve "local food." Only Rochester has this one, and its name is private property: Nick Tahou Hots has held the Garbage Plate trademark since the early 1990s. Our moat runs through someone else's deed.

TAKE THIS HOME

Would a plate make a newcomer feel like they belong here, or like they're being tested?